

Singing Dads Become Surprise Stars Online

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A group of singers near Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, became famous online without even trying.

The group is called the Tonics. They sing **a cappella**, which means without **instruments**. Most of the 18 members are dads and grandfathers. They practice in each other's kitchens.

Last year, the Tonics had about 500 **followers** on Instagram. Then, in December, they posted a video of themselves singing the song "Drift Away." It got 300,000 views! One later video got more than 4 million views.

"We were shocked," said Youngmoo Kim, the group's **music director**.

An online star named Emilie Hagen helped share their videos. She said the Tonics felt "**authentic** and **wholesome**."

The group started in 1990 with friends from school. Today, they have almost 100,000 **followers**. They plan to release four new songs on Spotify later this year.

Kim's advice is simple: just be yourself.

Word Treasure

a cappella -- A cappella means singing with only voices and no instruments.

instruments -- Instruments are things used to make music, like pianos and guitars.

followers -- Followers are people who sign up to see someone's posts online.

music director -- A music director leads a music group and helps it practice.

authentic -- Authentic means real and true, not fake.

wholesome -- Wholesome means good and nice for everyone.

Background you need

A cappella groups sing songs using only their voices.

On social media, a video can spread fast when lots of people share it.

Many people enjoy singing with friends as a hobby long after school.

Break it down

WHO: The Tonics, a group of 18 singers who are mostly dads and grandfathers

WHAT: They became famous online after posting videos of their singing

WHERE: Near Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, in members' kitchens

WHY: People liked that they seemed real and wholesome

Why it matters

The Tonics show kids that doing what you love and being yourself can make others happy too.

Test what you remember

1. What is the singing group called?

- ☐ (A) The Drifters
- ☐ (B) The Kitchens
- ☐ (C) The Dads
- ☐ (D) The Tonics

2. Where do the Tonics practice?

- ☐ (A) In each other's kitchens
- ☐ (B) On a boat
- ☐ (C) At the beach
- ☐ (D) In a big stadium

3. How many Instagram followers did they have last year?

- ☐ (A) About 100,000
- ☐ (B) About 500
- ☐ (C) About 4 million
- ☐ (D) None

4. Which song was in the video that got 300,000 views?

- ☐ (A) "Drift Away"
- ☐ (B) "Jingle Bells"
- ☐ (C) "Let It Go"
- ☐ (D) "Happy Birthday"

5. Who helped share their videos?

- ☐ (A) Youngmoo Kim
- ☐ (B) A famous movie star
- ☐ (C) Emilie Hagen
- ☐ (D) A news anchor

6. What is Kim's advice?

- ☐ (A) Only sing pop songs
- ☐ (B) Buy a microphone
- ☐ (C) Just be yourself
- ☐ (D) Practice every hour

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Emilie Hagen: She said the Tonics felt authentic and wholesome.
2. Youngmoo Kim: His advice is to just be yourself.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):